

RUMBLE IN THE HILLS

Two decades after a middle path was adopted, there is a renewed war cry for Gorkhaland as the new hero of the hills Bimal Gurung says he would settle for nothing less than a separate state



Photographs by SUBIR HALDAR

■ By Elora Sen

The crowds thronging the Bagdogra airport would have given anyone the impression that a famous cricketer or a film star was coming to the town. But the man they all waited anxiously for hours to catch a glimpse of was neither. Bimal Gurung—the man they are looking up to as their saviour, the one who has again given them the hope of a separate state Gorkhaland for Gorkhas—has the hills of north Bengal reverberating to that beat. The green, white and yellow flags of the Gorkha Jana Mukti Morcha (JMM)—Gurung's newly-floated party—can be seen flut-

tering everywhere. From Siliguri to Kurseong, Kalimpong to Darjeeling, the imagination of the masses is now being captured by the young Gorkha leader Gurung.

A cry that was raised years back in the 1980s by the chairman of Gorkha National Liberation Front (GNLF) Subhash Ghisingh is again in the forefront of national politics. But the man has now been pushed to the periphery. From someone, who, for decades, controlled every nook and corner of the hills, Ghisingh is now unable to step outside Siliguri. Confined to the state electricity board's guesthouse in the north Bengal town, Ghisingh stepped down as the administrator of the

FRESH BLOOD: Gurung arrives at Bagdogra airport

Darjeeling Gorkha Hill Council (DGHC) on March 10. The Gorkha leader left Darjeeling in the first week of February when JMM started an agitation against his continuation as DGHC chief and since then has not been able to go back to the hills. Though it was planned that after his resignation he will move up to the hills, he failed to do so. The official reason given was that he was suffering from chest congestion and fever and that the septuagenarian was advised by doctors not to make the trip. Ghisingh claims he agreed to step down as Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya had requested him to.

"I will not stop short of anything less than a Gorkhaland."

BIMAL GURUNG, LEADER OF GORKHA JANA MUKTI MORCHA